

THE 12 INTERVALS

Every musical distance between two notes — names, sizes, and the emotional quality each carries.

COMPLETE INTERVAL REFERENCE

INTERVAL NAME	ABBREV.	HALF STEPS	EXAMPLE FROM C	CHARACTER / FEEL
Unison / Octave	P1 / P8	0/12	C → C (same or upper)	Perfect consonance; grounded, complete, no tension
Minor 2nd	m2	1	C → D $\flat$	Maximum dissonance; friction, rub, urgency — horror film staple
Major 2nd	M2	2	C → D	Mild dissonance; stepwise motion, forward momentum, open
Minor 3rd	m3	3	C → E $\flat$	Soft consonance; minor quality, melancholy, introspective
Major 3rd	M3	4	C → E	Sweet consonance; major quality, brightness, stability, happiness
Perfect 4th	P4	5	C → F	Open, ancient; stable in context, slightly ambiguous in isolation
Tritone	Aug4/dim5	6	C → F $\sharp$ /G $\flat$	Maximum instability; divides octave in half, dominant tension engine
Perfect 5th	P5	7	C → G	Strong consonance; power, open, cornerstone of every chord
Minor 6th	m6	8	C → A $\flat$	Bittersweet; yearning, introspective — inversion of M3
Major 6th	M6	9	C → A	Warm, romantic; bright and uplifting — inversion of m3
Minor 7th	m7	10	C → B $\flat$	Mellow tension; jazzy, bluesy, mild dominant pull — inversion of M2
Major 7th	M7	11	C → B	Lush, dreamy; half-step from resolution, beautiful suspension — inversion of m2

HALF STEP (SEMITONE)

The smallest interval in Western music. The distance between any two adjacent notes on a piano (including black keys). E → F and B → C are natural half steps — no black key needed.

WHOLE STEP (WHOLE TONE)

Two half steps combined. Skip one key on the piano. C → D, D → E, F → G, G → A, A → B are all whole steps. E → F $\sharp$ and B → C $\sharp$ are also whole steps.

MAJOR SCALE FORMULA — W-W-H-W-W-W-H

